Rathedaung) and around the major port of Sittwe, while the rest of the province is mostly populated by ethnic Rakhine (see Figure 10).

Unlike in the rest of Myanmar, local parties—the RNDP and the ANP—dominate Rakhine politics:[6] the USDP is represented where there is a significant military presence but lacks a substantial popular base. Another difference is that the move to democracy has been even more partial than in the rest of the country. The military remains completely in control of the civilian administration, as a Rohingya activist explained to me—'There's no democracy in this township'—and the administrators are those 'who were administrator[s] during the time of the military regime. They are re-appointed. … So all people are under the administration of [the] military and their party administrator, township administrator. Where is the democracy?'[7]

Within Rakhine, many of the monasteries are also in close alliance with the RNDP and ANP.[8] This gives the Buddhist extremists a much closer hold over the political process here than they have elsewhere in Myanmar. When a charity wished to work with the monasteries to perform surgery to help local children with cleft lips, this was refused when they also wanted to treat children from the Rohingya community.[9]

In the period between 2008 and 2012 the persecution of the Rohingyas was continuous, and a US government report[10] noted that this had a particularly religious aspect. The period saw the destruction of many mosques which, it was claimed, had been built without proper permission, and saw the creation of 'Muslim Free Areas' in some parts of the state. In addition, Buddhist pagodas have been built in areas with no Buddhist population, often using Rohingya forced labour, and there is an ongoing campaign to entice conversion to Buddhism by lifting restrictions on travel, work and schooling for those who agree to do so.[11] In effect, those Rohingya prepared to change their religion received the same rights as other citizens.

This continuation of earlier policies of discrimination, including restrictions on family size and travel, reflects the RNDP's determination to force the Rohingyas out of Myanmar. On the most generous of interpretations, neither the NLD nor the military were prepared to challenge this policy; in reality they became complicit in allowing the RNDP to set